entire country belonged to both the communities'. For this reason, 'Bhagat Singh feared that if Lajpat Rai's idea of a division of the country along religious lines ever took shape, it would be disastrous' and that 'there would be a bloodbath'. And, of course, so it came to be. Bhagat Singh was proven right. Lajpat Rai was proven wrong. This is not to say that Lajpat Rai did not in turn think Bhagat Singh to be equally mistaken in his philosophy. In fact, while Bhagat Singh 'regretted his tilt towards Hindu chauvinism', the fact was that 'Lajpat Rai, in turn, had denounced him as a "Russian agent"' and even 'regarded revolutionaries as "irresponsible" young men'.[6]

Not surprisingly Bhagat Singh, the martyr, political activist, thinker, revolutionary, took a different view. That he should do so is interesting. Deviating from a man whom he had always looked up to, however, was based on high principle. This is today unrecognized because Bhagat Singh is known for the most part only as a revolutionary firebrand. This in turn is because what we know of him comes from the stand that Bhagat Singh so boldly took before the judges of the special tribunal before whom he was beaten and humiliated and yet remained staunchly defiant to the end. But there was another Bhagat Singh. This was Bhagat Singh the writer and journalist. This is important because in his writings Bhagat Singh strongly castigated communalism in favour of a society based on tolerance, pluralism, diversity and broad-mindedness.

The main differences between the two of them arose from the fact that Bhagat Singh was a socialist. Lala Lajpat Rai was not. In a piece written in Punjabi in 1928, 'Lala Lajpat Rai and the Youth', Bhagat Singh explains how Lala Lajpat Rai had dismissed, 'these propagandist young men as misguided'.[7] He notes how 'Lalaji says that our socialist ideas will cause the capitalists to join forces with the government', but disagreeing with him Bhagat Singh ventures to ask: 'How many capitalists have become harbingers of change?'. The reality is that '[i]n a revolution anyone who fears his wealth and property may be harmed will always oppose it', which is why '[i]n such a situation, to abandon one's principles to appease them and damage our own cause is not appropriate'.[8] In a searing critique, which exposes the difference between Bhagat Singh and his mentor, he adds: